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Rethinking Conservation: Deconstructing the Wilderness

We are on the unceded and ancestral territory of the hə́ŋqəmiŋəŋ and Sk̓wx̓wú7mesh speaking peoples, the x̣wməθḳwəỵəm (Musqueam), Sk̓wx̓wú7mesh (Squamish), and səliłwətał (Tsleil-Waututh) Nations, and has been stewarded by them since time immemorial.



FCOR 599

Interactive Presentation

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The Trouble with Wilderness

or,

Getting Back to the Wrong Nature

William Cronon

THE TIME HAS COME TO RETHINK WILDERNESS.

This will seem a heretical claim to many environmentalists, since the idea of wilderness has for decades been a fundamental tenet—indeed, a passion—of the environmental movement, especially in the United States. For many Americans wilderness stands as the last remaining place where civilization, that all too human disease, has not fully infected the earth.

Cronon's Argument: Rethinking Wilderness

- Wilderness = cultural idea, not “pure nature”
- Idea shaped by Romantic writers, Biblical stories, and the American frontier myth
- Human/Nature divide is the core problem
- Wilderness was never empty - Indigenous peoples shaped it

The Human/Nature Binary

- “Nature = pristine wilderness”
- “Humans = outside, harmful, separate”
- Erases Indigenous presence
- Makes cities and daily environments seem “not nature”
- Leads to unrealistic conservation goals

What Cronon Wants

- Recognize nature everywhere
- Value human-shaped and urban landscapes
- Support Indigenous land-care knowledge
- Move beyond wilderness vs. civilization
- Focus on coexistence

<https://pancakehousempls.com/American-Mythless>



Why It Matters: Social & Political Cost

Social Inequality

Political Control

- **Whose Environment?** Hides the real crisis for the poor (jobs, housing, discrimination).
- **Cultural Bias:** Creates a false "Good Country" vs. "Bad City" binary.
- **Exclusion:** Ignores human settlements as part of the ecosystem.

- **Ecological Imperialism:** Imposes Western ideals on local populations (Decolonizing Conservation).
 - **Displacement:** Justifies evicting Indigenous communities for "pure" parks.
 - **Undemocratic:** Requires rigid, centralized power structures.
-

Why It Matters: The Economic Trap

■ Commodification and The Anti-Ecological Dollar

- **Commodification:** Nature is reduced to market value, stripping it of intrinsic moral dignity.
- **The "Externality" Flaw:** Ecosystems are treated as outside the economy, rather than the foundation of it.
- **Incentives:** Short-term profit (e.g., luxury ecotourism) often overrides long-term environmental survival.

Why It Matters: The Environmental Truth

The ultimate truth is that the pristine wilderness does not exist.

Human action has modified every single corner of the planet.

We must stop seeking an "outside" nature. We are fundamentally embedded in it.

Our social and economic choices are ecological choices.



Spectrum 1: Human Presence & Management



The Preservation - Conservation Spectrum

“The only thing we have to preserve nature with is culture; the only thing we have to preserve wildness with is domesticity.”

-Wendell Berry



- No human intervention
- “Hands off” approach
- Designated wilderness, “leave no trace” zones
- Example: Frank Church-River of No Return Wilderness in Idaho

- Deliberate restoration
- “Careful hands” approach
- Species reintroduction, controlled burns
- Example: Leopold’s Sand County Almanac

- Sustainable production
- “Working hands” approach
- Sustainable forestry, indigenous food systems
- Example: PNW forests before colonization

- Active human inhabitation
- “Living hands” approach
- Example: Urban parks, community gardens, your backyard, green roofs



The Preservation Paradox

“If we allow ourselves to believe that nature, to be true, must also be wild, then our very presence in nature represents its fall. The place where we are is the place where nature is not”

-William Cronon

■ Wilderness Ideology says:

■ Ecological Reality shows:

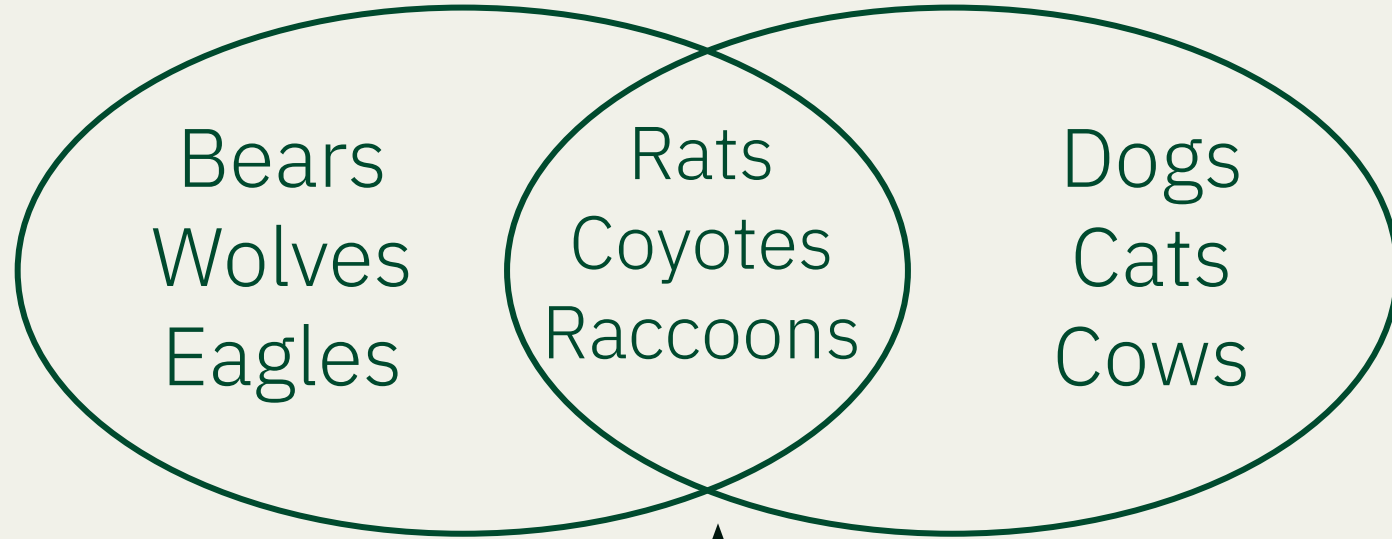
"Don't touch it—it's pristine"	Many "pristine" landscapes were actively managed
"Human intervention = degradation"	Some ecosystems require intervention to thrive
"Leave no trace"	Sometimes our traces can heal
"Nature knows best"	"Nature" includes 10,000 years of human presence

Spectrum 2: Wildlife, Liminal Animals, and Pests



Wilderness

Domestic

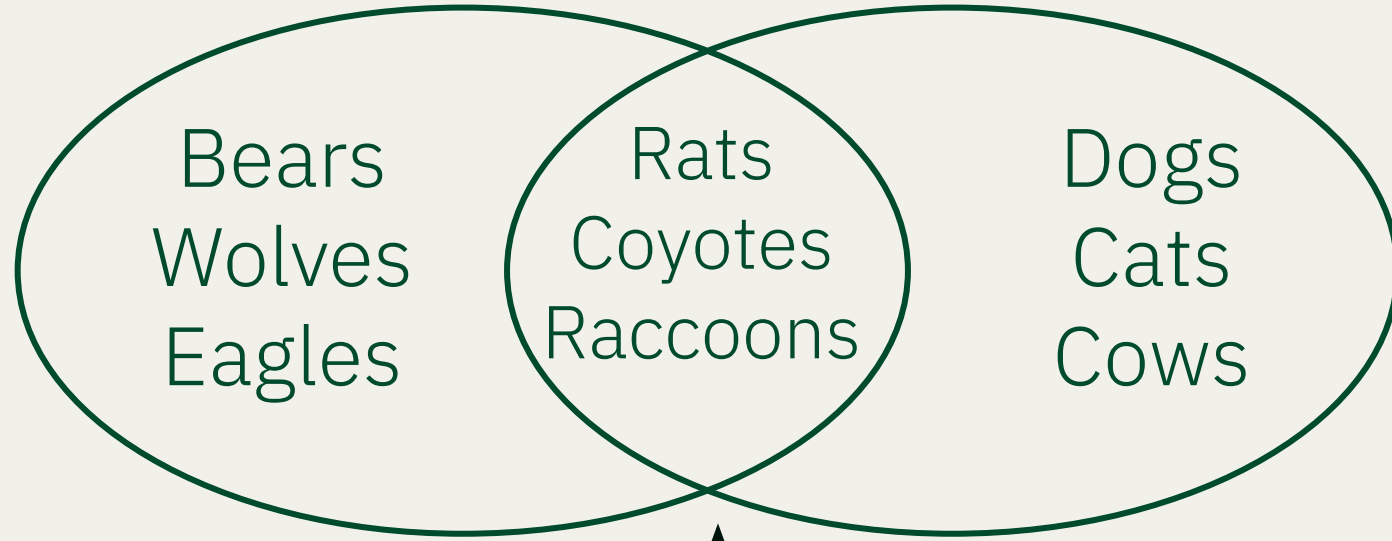


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Wilderness

Domestic



Pests?



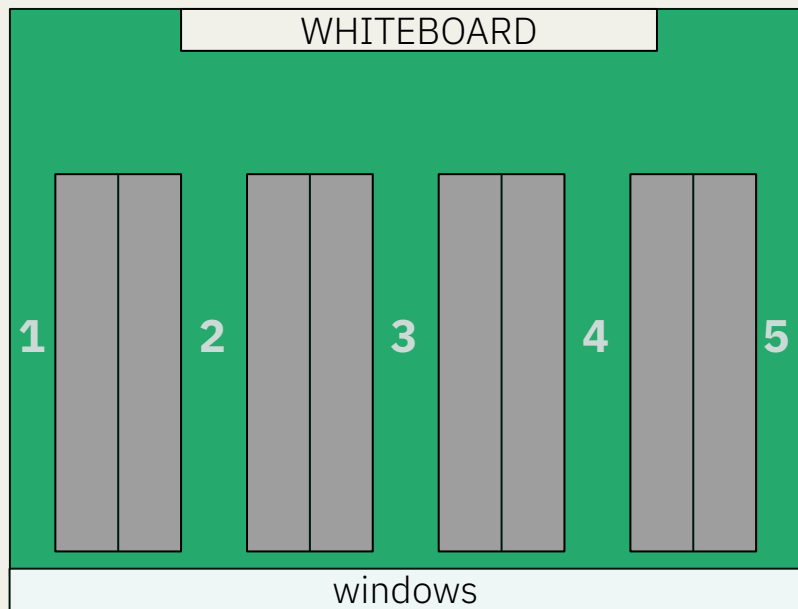
Category	Example	Political Theory	Our Obligation
Wilderness Animals	Wolves in Yellowstone	Sovereign	Rights to territory and autonomy
Domestic Animals	Pets, livestock	Citizens	Members of our society
Liminal Animals	Urban coyotes, raccoons, pigeons	Denizens	Rights to residency without participation in our society

Animals and the Frontier of Citizenship
(Donaldson & Kymlicka, 2014)



ACTIVITY

Case Studies



INSTRUCTIONS

10 minutes to read the case study and discuss the provided questions as a table row group.

10 minutes for each group to summarize their case study and present their key findings to the whole class.

INSTRUCTIONS

You have **10 minutes** to read the case study and discuss the provided questions with your table row group.



10:00

DOWNLOAD THE
CASE STUDIES
HERE OR VIA
THE SLACK LINK

Be sure to reference the ideas
introduced in the lecture.

10 minutes for each group to summarize their case study and present their key findings to the whole class.

WHOLE CLASS DISCUSSION

1. **SUMMARIZE** YOUR CASE STUDY
2. **ANSWER:** HOW DID IT CONNECT TO THE LECTURE MATERIAL?
3. SHARE **REFLECTIONS** AND ADDITIONAL **COMMENTS**

composition space we exist in abiotic and biotic factor
 squirrels landscape mgem rocks vegetation
 sustainability land trees forest lacking human influence
 things we see everything nature gem500 python
 everything that surrounds environment itself
 fracking woooooo animals plants eco
 yes place i love outside fresh airrrrr green natural spacew area
 people animals land pineapple tree
 difficult to learn the place we live in

untamed fauna savanna
 unrestricted insects count too respect
 fear not domesticated
 people animals nature wild animals
 wild and life hunting
 caribou killing plants squirrels tensions
 danger animal large cats and whatnot raccoons

mother nature everything
 environment animals conservation
 relaxing
 god forest moss trees wild
 not artificial green plants earth outside value
 rocks yes pineapple
 lacking human influence originalll people animals land
 tree beauty

menti polls from the beginning of the presentation.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

■ Deconstructing the Wilderness

- Cultural Invention
- Human/Nature Binary
- Important for Conservation Work

■ Why this Matters

- Social Inequality
- Political Control
- Economic Value
- Environment

■ Spectrums

Practical Issues

1. Human Presence
2. Wildlife - Liminal Animals - Pests

Consider: Case Studies

■ Apply Reflexivity

- Where does your perspective come from?
- What are implicit assumptions in your work?
- How can you challenge them?

Thank you for your participation and engagement!

Comments? Questions? Concerns?

- Berry, W. (2008). “Preserving Wildness.” *American Earth: Environmental Writing Since Thoreau*. Ed. Bill McKibben, Ed. Al Gore. New York, NY: Literary Classics of the United States.
- Cronon, W. (1996). The Trouble with Wilderness: Or, Getting Back to the Wrong Nature. *Environmental History*, 1(1), pp. 7-28, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/3985059?origin=JSTOR-pdf>.
- Donaldson, S. & Kymlicka, W. (2014). Animals and the frontiers of citizenship. *Oxford Journal of Legal Studies*, 34(2). pp. 201-219, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ojls/gqu001>.

Presentation
Outline

AI used to generate an initial presentation outline and case study materials.

REFERENCES

AI DECLARATION